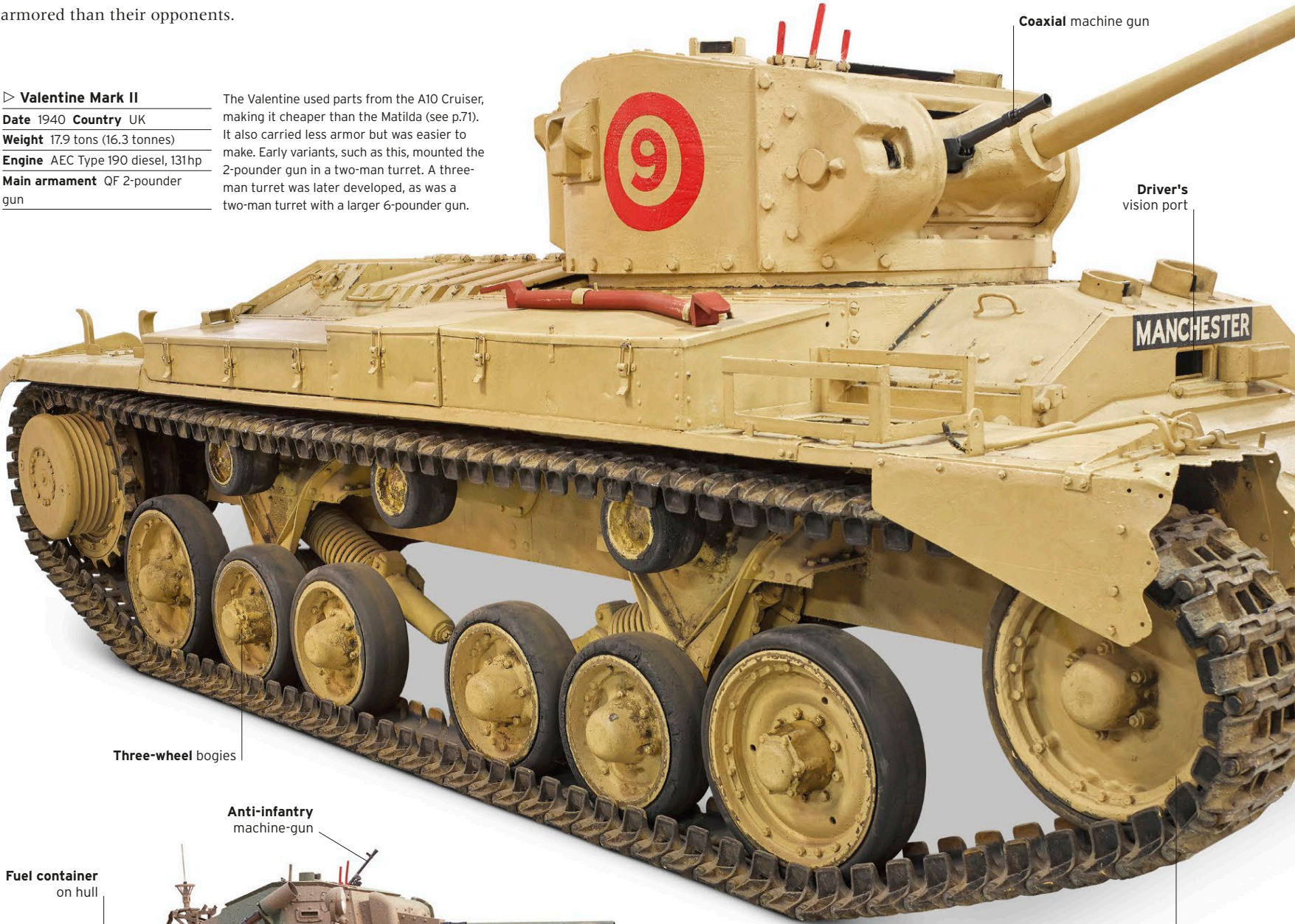


UK and Commonwealth Tanks

After evacuating from France, Britain had very few tanks available, and a German invasion was believed to be imminent. Due to this danger, it was decided to continue building older, less capable vehicles rather than accept the delays in production that would result from designing new vehicles and modifying factories to build them. This, combined with a restriction on size and weight, brought about by the need to fit tanks on railroad cars, meant that throughout the war British tanks were almost always less well-armored than their opponents.

▷ Valentine Mark II
Date 1940 Country UK
Weight 17.9 tons (16.3 tonnes)
Engine AEC Type 190 diesel, 131hp
Main armament QF 2-pounder gun

The Valentine used parts from the A10 Cruiser, making it cheaper than the Matilda (see p.71). It also carried less armor but was easier to make. Early variants, such as this, mounted the 2-pounder gun in a two-man turret. A three-man turret was later developed, as was a two-man turret with a larger 6-pounder gun.



Three-wheel bogies

Anti-infantry machine-gun

Coaxial machine gun

Driver's vision port

Idler wheel



Fuel container on hull

Driver's vision port

◁ Tetrarch (Close Support)
Date 1940 Country UK
Weight 8.4 tons (7.6 tonnes)
Engine Meadows 12-cylinder gasoline, 165 hp
Main armament 3in howitzer

The A13 Covenanter shared only the Christie suspension with earlier A13s. It had several faults. The engine radiators were attached to the hull front, leading to cooling problems. The tank used steel wheels instead of aluminum, which increased weight and stressed the suspension. It was mostly used for training.

A prewar design with a 2-pounder gun, the Tetrarch was intended to improve the firepower of British light tanks. However, the Battle of France proved their vulnerability. The few Tetrarchs produced were allocated to airborne forces, with some used during D-Day landings in June 1944. These were withdrawn by August.